

Clouds

Toru Takemitsu

About

Japanese composer Toru Takemitsu (1930–1996) was largely self-taught. His career began with the formation, in 1951, of the Jikken Kobo (Experimental Workshop) intended to promote and perform mixed-media art works. Stylistically, he combined elements of Eastern and Western music along with philosophy to create his own sound world.

Influences included Debussy and Messiaen, as well as Webern and John Cage. Takemitsu wrote experimental music involving unusual instrument combinations, natural and recorded sounds, improvisation, as well as graphic notation. This often resulted in slow, soft, delicate works which are of great intensity and beauty.

The *Requiem for String Orchestra* (1957) attracted international attention, leading to commissions worldwide, establishing his reputation as one of the leading 20th century Japanese composers. Takemitsu wrote several hundred works, he scored over ninety films and published twenty books, and he also won numerous awards and prizes.

Clouds is one of two pieces which form the set entitled *Piano Pieces for Children*. Written in 1979, both pieces were composed for the children's programme, *Piano no Okeiko* (Piano Lessons) at the request of the programme's instructor, Naoyuki Inoue.

In performance

In the key of A major, *Clouds* is an introspective work, featuring a smooth, *legato* melodic line combined with a gently oscillating left hand accompaniment.

Start by playing the left hand quaver patterns as chords (bars 1–21 and bars 29–34) in order to easily locate all notes, fingerings and hand position changes. The crotchet beats, which often form the lowest note in the bar (for example, at bars 1–2), act as pedal notes, or sustained tones, which must be held for their entirety; these pedal notes help sustain the sound, contributing to the gentle, expressive character. Be mindful of the pairs of slurred quavers, too.

The right hand part will require a deeper touch, particularly accented notes, as at bars 1 and 7 (F#s), as well as the semiquaver triplet note pattern, like those in bars 3, 5 and 6, which add sonority and, often, an unusual harmonic twist, to the melodic material. Be sure to colour the falling melodic intervals from bars 9–12, and their re-appearance at bars 29–32. A higher register is employed from bars 15–21, proffering an intensity, before the theme is passed to the left hand part from bars 23–27.

A change of character at bars 33 and 34 demands a lighter touch and, in the left hand part, crisp, *staccato* articulation, before the final two chords drift off into the distance. Musical markings abound in this piece, so attention to detail will be paramount — aim to observe all tempo changes, as at bars 12, 20, 32, and 34.

Melanie Spanswick

Clouds

from *Piano Pieces for Children*

Toru Takemitsu
(1930-96)

Andante ♩ = 48-60

mf poco

p

p

con Ped. (ad lib.)

4

p

mf

(p)

poco

f

mf

p

poco

8

p

mf

mp

mf

12

poco rit.

a tempo

mf

p

(mf)

p

dolce

R.H.

(mf poco)

pp

16

mf *p*

20

poco rit. a tempo

p *p* *p* *p*

24

mf

28

p *mf* *mp* *mf*

32

poco rit. a tempo leggiero poco rit.

mf *p* *(mf)* *p* *p* *mf* *pp* *p*

dolce